no useful purpose, given that their club is not an alliance and the members have important political differences and geopolitical rivalries. The original four BRICs all rank in the top eleven countries in military spending. Russia, India, and China are also nuclear weapon states. Brazil and South Africa both had nuclear weapons programs, but they voluntarily abandoned them in the 1980s and 1990s, respectively.

In global terms, an important turning point occurred in 2012 when Asian defense spending (excluding Australia and New Zealand) surpassed the defense spending of European members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), reflecting in part the impact of Europe's high debt-to-GDP ratios and severe defense austerity that had shrunk NATO Europe's nominal defense spending in 2012 to 2006 levels. Although West European states started cutting their defense budgets at the end of the Cold War, after the global financial crisis started, NATO European defense budgets contracted at a faster rate than their economies were declining, a trend that was stemmed only after Russia's armed intervention in Ukraine and annexation of Crimea. By 2015, Asia was spending about $100 billion more on defense than Europe.[101]

TABLE 2.1

Global Defense Rankings and Trends, 1993–2016

Global Rank						Spending as a Share of GDP (%)	
2016	1993b	Country	Spending 2016 ($ bn, MER)	Change 2007–2016 (%)	World Share 2016 (%)	2016	2007
1	1	United States	611	−4.8	36	3.3	3.8
2	3	China	215a	118	13a	1.9a	1.9a
3	2	Russia	69.2	87	4.1	5.3	3.4
4	9	Saudi Arabia	63.7a	20	3.8a	10a	8.5
5	13	India	55.9	54	3.3	2.5	2.3
6	4	France	55.7	2.8	3.3	2.3	2.3
7	7	UK	48.3	−12	2.9	1.9	2.2
8	5	Japan	46.1	2.5	2.7	1.0	0.9
9	6	Germany	41.1	6.8	2.4	1.2	1.2
10	10	South Korea	36.8	35	2.2	2.7	2.5
11	8	Italy	27.9	−16	1.7	1.5	1.6
12	15	Australia	24.6	29	1.5	2.0	1.8
13	19	Brazil	23.7	18	1.4	1.3	1.5

Sources: Trends in World Military Expenditure, SIPRI (2016); World Military Expenditures and Arms Transfers (WMEAT) 1993–1994, U.S. Arms Control and Disarmament Agency (1995); C. Roberts calculations.

[a] SIPRI estimates. Dollar figures are current prices and exchange rates, while figures for percentage changes over time are in constant (2015) US dollars.

[b] WMEAT rankings are based on current prices and exchange rates.

Given that growth in GDP and growth in military spending are strongly correlated over the long term,[102] it is notable that the four BRICs have been steadily moving up in the top ten rankings of both world economies and leading defense spenders, while a substantial share of global defense spending has been shifting away from the United States, and particularly its allies. As Table 2.1 shows, between 2007 and 2016, China's defense spending soared 118 percent, while Russia, India, and Brazil increased their defense budgets 87, 54, and 18 percent, respectively. From 2010 to 2015, China's defense spending rose from 18 to 36 percent of U.S. defense